shooting at American planes with what amounted to acceptance of his proposed swap.

Everyone was going in a separate direction. People were exhausted, irritable, and generally at a loss. To complicate matters, Curtis LeMay and the Chiefs of Staff rejected the idea of a retaliatory strike against the SAM missiles, as they believed—correctly, as it turned out—that some nuclear missiles were already operational in Cuba. A strike against a SAM might therefore provoke a nuclear response from the Soviets. Accordingly, the chiefs wanted not a discriminatory strike but an all-out attack on Cuba as soon as possible. The window of opportunity for Kennedy and Khrushchev to make a deal was closing rapidly, and on the afternoon of October 27 it was anything but clear whether they could make the deadline.[4]

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TWO HOURS LATER, ROBERT KENNEDY BRIEFED HIS BROTHER privately on the continuing debates in ExCom. “He talked about Major Anderson and how it is always the brave and the best who die,” wrote Robert Kennedy, recalling a meeting with his brother on the evening of October 27. Describing the trend of his brother’s thoughts, he went on: “The politicians and officials sit home pontificating about great principles and issues, make the decisions, and dine with their wives and families, while the brave and the young die.” John Kennedy then switched to his favorite topic, the danger of miscalculation, but according to Robert the gist of the conversation was to make sure that “every opportunity was … given to the Russians to find a peaceful settlement which would not diminish their national security or be a public humiliation.”[5]

Whether Robert Kennedy’s recollection of the words spoken by his brother that evening is accurate or not, there is no doubt that the downing of the U-2 and the death of the pilot strengthened Kennedy’s determination to prevent war in any way possible, which meant accommodating the Soviets. All day he had fought to convince his aides that the only way to get rid of the missiles in Cuba was to swap them for those in Turkey. General Taylor told the Chiefs of Staff in his report on the ExCom meeting that afternoon